

The Flow of Debate/Notetaking

During the debate, you need to take notes on what is said by both teams, and you need to take those notes FAST! In order to do this, you will want to learn a specialized form of note taking developed just for debating. This method is known as “flowing the debate.” In this method, you will write down your arguments and what the other side says about those arguments – you FLOW those arguments across the flow sheet.

For Parli debate, it’s usually a good idea to get legal-sized paper (longer than regular 8 x 11) and turn it horizontally. Then divide the paper into 6 columns, labeling each column for a speech that will be given in the debate. Do the six columns on BOTH sides of the paper. Here’s what it should look like:

Resolution (exact wording) _____					

How Do You Put Your Notes in these Columns?

In the first column, you will write down the Affirmation case as it is presented. (If you are the Affirmation, you can do this during your prep time once you decide on the points.) **YOU NEED TO ABBREVIATE**, and **YOU NEED TO LEAVE SPACE BETWEEN EACH POINT**. As much as you can, you also need to write down facts, statistics, and sources. Even though you’re writing fast, you want it to be as legible and complete as possible. Your partner may need to read what you’ve written, and let’s face it, it can be embarrassing if you can’t read your own handwriting during your speech! If the AFF is presenting a plan, write it down as well.

In the second column, you will write down the NEGATION’S response to each item presented in the Affirmation’s case, and you write it RIGHT ACROSS FROM THE POINT IT RELATES TO. For the negation’s case (their own specific contentions, you will flip the paper over to the backside and write their case arguments in the second column. Again, leave space between each point.

In the remaining speeches, you will continue to write the responses to each argument next to the argument to which they are related. In this way, you can see how an argument developed – what the argument was, what was said to break it down, and what was said to rebuild the argument etc.

If an argument is dropped, you will also want to mark this on your flow sheet. Sometimes teams draw a circle in the place where it was dropped or write DROP on the flow. (See the sample.) Finally, in rebuttals, the key arguments – AKA the VOTING issues – need to be clearly listed.

Creating your own system of shorthand and symbols will be key to capturing lots of information in a short period of time. Any system you create need to achieve the following goals; a recording of all the arguments in the debate, the responses made to those arguments in the entire round, and what were the voting issues in the debate. The ultimate goal is to be able to pull out your flow at the next practice and be able to recount what happened in the debate from your perspective and compare that to what feedback is available from the ballot in the round.